The first step to lasting peace is ensuring a successful cessation of hostilities and constituting a national political dialogue. The seventeen-year-old ceasefire between the KIO/A and the Tatmadaw ended in June 2011, just as the Karen National Union and many other insurgent groups signed individual ceasefire agreements with the government in early 2012. The KIO/A have maintained demands for agreement about political dialogue before they will agree again to a ceasefire, based on their inability to get to dialogue during their last ceasefire. They signed a tentative and fragile Kachin accord in 2013, a ceasefire in all but name, and were part of the drafting of the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement (NCA) signed by eight armed groups on 15 October 2015. However, subsequent Tatmadaw attacks on KIA positions, and the KIO/A boycott on signing the NCA even after the commencement of a political dialogue convention on 12 January 2016, are significant. Political dialogue will be a long road, posing great difficulty.

Based on our analysis of interview data and the literature, it seems clear that the KIO/A and many Kachin are not yet convinced the government is committed to addressing what they see as central issues: political rights, power distribution, state power versus decentralized authority, and the quest for equality and freedom. Many Kachin need their equal citizenship rights affirmed and to see agreement over decentralization and power sharing before they can let go of their ethno-nationalist agenda and regard themselves as citizens of Myanmar who are of Kachin cultural identity. In essence, what is required is a redefinition of the concept of citizenship in Myanmar beyond the nationalist/ethno-nationalist rhetoric that generates spheres of exclusion from the political process for a significant part of the population. It is a call for a clear and inclusive answer to the question of who the demos are in Myanmar's future democracy. This will undoubtedly involve constitutional change, something the government has been reticent to consider to this point.

This analysis leads us to conclude with two challenges for the peace process in Myanmar. Firstly, the next round of political dialogue will need to genuinely address these fundamental issues, which will not be easy. The danger perceived by KIO/A leadership and many Kachin appears to be that if political dialogue fails to address these underlying issues, further state encroachment into Kachin State through service delivery, development activities, and resource exploitation will undermine any chance of later renegotiation. There appears to be truth in this, although the KIA continues to lose ground militarily too, so this may be the only